OLD WALLS, NEW LIVES

Four architects. Four forgotten structures. One powerful argument for saving what already stands

By SHAHZEB ATHAR

The easiest thing to do with an old building is to tear it down. In India's fast-growing cities that instinct has become almost reflexive. Pull permits; clear the plot; pour fresh concrete. It is faster and involves none of the legal complexity or structural uncertainty that comes with working within existing walls. But a quieter counter-movement is gaining ground. Across Goa's coastal villages and the suburban sprawl of Gurgaon, a new generation of architects are championing the art of giving old structures a second life. The homes that result carry something that new buildings simply cannot manufacture: the weight of what came before. They also carry something that the demolition quietly destroys, every kilogramme of steel, concrete and timber in an existing structure represents energy already spent and carbon already emitted. To tear it down is to waste that embedded cost entirely and then spend it again. In a country building at India's pace, that math is becoming impossible to ignore.





Photograph by JEETIN SHARMA

ROOM SERVICE (clockwise from previous page) Master bedroom, Publisher's Home by Studio Tilt; a living space, Toybox project by Grounded; drawing room, House of Continuity by groupDCA